MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume VII | Issue III | Summer 2017



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Page 7 BBQ Tickets!

SPECIAL FEATURE:

Vintage Villa Street: Here Today, Gone Tomorrow?



THE MVHA SHARES THE HISTORY OF TWO VILLA STREET BUILDINGS THREATENED BY NEW DEVELOPMENT

This past spring, the Mountain View Historical Association learned that the owners of Chez TJ restaurant and the Tied House Microbrewery have partnered with a local developer, the Minkoff Group, to replace the two restaurants with a new four-story office building. Commercial space would be located on the ground floor, with tentative plans to combine the two existing restaurants into a new dining concept in the space.

In light of this development proposal, the Historical Association has prepared articles on the histories of the structures currently located on the site of the proposed development: the historic Weilheimer House at 938 Villa Street and the Air Base Laundry building at 954 Villa Street. We will also be discussing this topic at our Summer Membership Meeting & BBQ on August 20.

The MVHA Board's goal is to share with the community and our elected leaders the history of both properties to help inform upcoming decisions on their future. We hope you'll find the information on the Weilheimer House (page 4-5) and Air Base Laundry (page 7) both interesting and informative.



MOUNTAIN REVIEW

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

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Hop on Board!

Help chart the future of your historical association! If you are interested in any vacant positions above, please contact us today.

For more info contact:

MVHA Board of Directors
Email: info@mountainviewhistorical.org
Voicemail: (650) 903-6890

News & Notes

President's Message

By Candace Bowers
MVHA President

Happy summer!

We're now in the midst of one of our favorite times of the year: the time for local stone fruit and Linda's burgers. By the time you read this, this year's crop of the famous Blenheim apricots will be gone, but we can still enjoy local cherries and other fruit. I'm feeling grateful for the heritage orchards in our neighboring cities that still grow these treasures on a commercial scale. If you missed the fresh Blenheims, you can still find them as dried halves or the extra-tasty "slabs," which are the especially ripe apricots that flatten out as they dry. Don't be fooled by their thinner appearance—they are soft and sweet, and many local folks prefer them.

We'll soon be firing up the grills for our annual summer BBQ! Well, actually, we won't be manning the grills ourselves this year. Don't worry, we'll still be serving the traditional Parisian Burger, but we're giving our grill-master volunteers a break and are instead having the Gold Rush Eatery cater the event. The Gold Rush Eatery is a restaurant located in Sunnyvale's Sunken Gardens Golf Course that specializes in recreating the Parisian Burger. A bit of history from their website explains the connection:

"Kris and Kris are the father and son team, who wanted to open a restaurant that specializes in quality comfort food at an affordable price. Inspired by the famous Linda's Drive Thru, a popular eatery in Mountain View, California in the 60's, 70's and 80's, the father and son team decided on a whole new venture, and Gold Rush Eatery was born. The signature menu item, The Gold Rush Burger is their version of Linda's "Parisian Burger," it boasts 1/2 lb. Black Angus Beef and a handcrafted San Francisco Sourdough bun. Gold Rush Eatery promises to use only the freshest ingredients, and fresh, never frozen beef in their burgers."

We're sure you won't be disappointed in their version of this legendary Mountain View dish!

We'll also take some time at the BBQ to discuss the proposed project at 938–954 Villa Street. There's been a lot of interest in this project among our members, and residents are forming a group to share their concerns about the potential loss of these historic sites (see below). We'll share what we know, and will give you a chance to share your thoughts, too.

See you at the Adobe—

Candace

New Group, Livable Mtn. View

By Nick Perry
MVHA Vice President

Jerry Steach, the recently elected chair of the Old Mountain View Neighborhood Association's Historic Preservation Committee, has contacted the MVHA to share the news of the formation of a new group, "Livable Mountain View." The group is currently focused on the future of 938-954 Villa Street and the potential for a win-win solution for both the property owners and the community, with a goal of preserving the site's historic structures in Downtown Mountain View. If you're interested in getting involved, please contact Jerry at: jsteach@pacbell.net.

History Center Update

By Candace Bowers
MVHA President

We're excited to let you know that plans are underway to digitize the History Center's photo collection. The History Center is run jointly by the MVHA and the Mountain View Library, and houses historic photographs that belong to both groups. Some years ago, many of these photos were scanned digitally and uploaded to the Library's online catalog. (For those of you who don't do computers, this means that you could look up a photo of, say, the Castro family just as easily as looking up a book about them.) However, the image quality was not the best, and the photos themselves weren't always easy to find among all those books.

More recently, a project was developed to collect the historic photos of various California cities on one web site, known as California Revealed. Although the project is being carried out by local libraries, it includes other local groups, such as historical associations. The bulk of our photos have already been sent out for scanning, and we hope to have them available online by the end of the year.

The digitization project includes other media such as audiotapes. This means that the master tapes from the oral history interviews that became the three-book set entitled *Bittersweet: Memories of Old Mountain View* will be heard once more. These tapes have been in storage since *Bittersweet* was published in 1980. Once they are digitized, the personal stories of Mountain View's Japanese, Mexican, and Spanish communities will literally be heard in their own voices.

Bobby Kinchen Memorial

By Nick Perry
MVHA Vice President

The MVHA Board is advancing plans to install a memorial plaque in honor of our late City Historian, Barbara "Bobby" Kinchen, in the History Center. The proposed plaque will feature of portrait of Barbara and a short inscription that describes her role in preserving Mountain View's history. Barbara's daughter recently sent the Board a selection of photos to consider for the plaque's portrait. We will keep members posted on the plaque via this newsletter. If you have any questions, please contact any Board member.

Financial Report

By Emily Ramos
MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 4/10/2017: $20,872.17
Income: $700.32
Expenses: $472.99
Checking Account Balance as of 7/7/2017: $21,099.50

Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 4/10/2017: $59,958.66
Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 7/7/2017: $59,958.66

Membership Report

By Lisa Garcia
MVHA Membership Chair

Happy Summer to all our members and friends! Thank you to those of you who have renewed your membership since our last newsletter. Please bear with me as I am updating all of our records. If you have not renewed your membership it's never too late! It's the perfect time to get your BBQ ticket AND renew your membership.

If you have any questions on the status of your membership, please email mvha.membership@gmail.com or write us at the address listed on the membership form (see page 7) or you can call me at 650-215-0254 (Lisa Garcia). I hope to see all of you at the BBQ in August. If we haven't met yet please drop by the membership table and say "Hi!"

Membership as of July 25, 2017

Honored Members	1
Life Members	111
Family Members	60
Single Members	62
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP	**234**

New Members: Eric Anderson, Dian Langdon, Jerome Camp, Martha Wallace, Irene Yoshida, Steven Nelson
New Life Member: Margaret Abe-Koga

Immigrant House Update

By Marina Marinovich
MVHA Publicity Chair

Good news! The city has created an application form to submit with photos of items you'd like considered for inclusion in the static display at Immigrant House. This will help to speed along the process of acquiring the appropriate historic items. On the master list of items needed are a stove, a heat source, a bed, items for the kitchen, and a washbasin.

To maintain the authenticity of the exhibit, items must be from the 1920s or before. Photos and a description of said items need to be approved by the city for possible inclusion. Items must be approved as historically and aesthetically accurate by the city before actually being acquired or purchased.

We are hoping to have the furnishing completed by the park's first birthday – December 10, 2018. Stay tuned for information regarding the Grand Reveal!

Those interested in joining the volunteer effort to obtain furnishings are encouraged to call Mary Kay "Marina" Marinovich, c/o Friends of Immigrant House, at this NEW phone number: (650) 823-9766.

The Weilheimer House

By Nick Perry
MVHA Vice President

The City Council will soon be asked to decide the fate of one of our city's most notable historic structures, the Weilheimer House, located at 938 Villa Street. Today, the house is known throughout the region as Chez TJ, one of the Bay Area's most notable fine-dining establishments. But its history stretches far past the arrival of any Michelin stars in Mountain View.

To understand the significance of the Weilheimer House, we need to go back all the way to the original founding of Mountain View in the 1850s and share the history of the Weilheimer family, one of Mountain View's leading pioneer families and one of the few Jewish families to settle in the region during its earliest era of development.

In the 1850s, the primary mode of travel on the Peninsula was stagecoach and the most popular route traversed El Camino Real, then known as the San Francisco-San Jose Road. A natural stopping point was where the road forded Stevens Creek and a stagecoach stop was established. Throughout the 1850s and 1860s, a diverse group of enterprising pioneers opened businesses near the stagecoach stop and named their town "Mountain View."

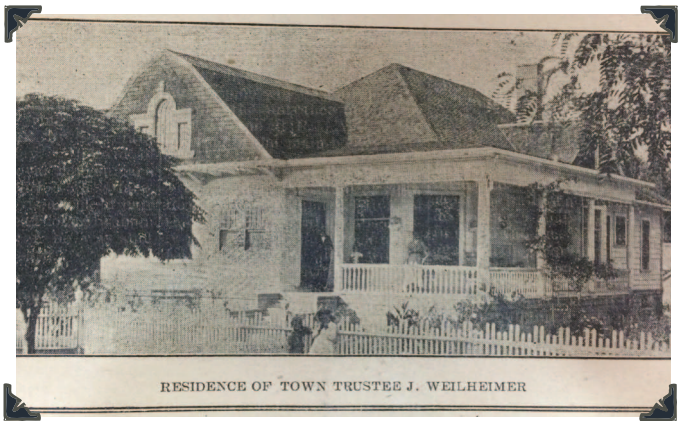
Among those original pioneers were brothers Seligman and Samuel Weilheimer. Seligman arrived in the area in 1852 from Dossenheim, Germany. His brother followed three years later and together they opened a general merchandise store in Mountain View. In 1856, Seligman married Sophie Baer. After their wedding in San Francisco they took the stagecoach to their new home in Mountain View, where Sophie helped the brothers run their general store.

When the newly constructed railroad (today's Caltrain) bypassed Mountain View in 1864, a "New Mountain View" emerged near the train depot. Castro Street became the new community's downtown. The Weilheimers were among the first merchants to set up shop on Castro Street; they opened a second branch of their general store (Mountain View's first "chain" store!) at 124 Castro Street in 1870. It was originally known as the "Farmer's Store." The one-story Italianate commercial building is still there today; likely now one of the oldest commercial buildings standing in northern Santa Clara County.

The Weilheimers expanded their businesses in New Mountain View. As noted in *Milestones: A History of Mountain View,*



The Weilheimers' Farmer's Store (left) and the Weilheimer's Hotel (right) were two of the first buildings on Castro Street.



The Weilheimer House as featured on the front page of the Mtn. View *Register* on March 5, 1905.



The Weilheimer House as it appears today.

"A visitor stepping off the train in Mountain View would immediately see Weilheimer's Hotel with its adjacent livery and horse corral that faced Front Street [now Evelyn Avenue]." In 1882, Samuel and his family moved to San Francisco. Seligman remained and continued to run the family businesses and also became the town's Wells Fargo agent.

Seligman and Sophie's children were among the very first generation to be born and reared in Mountain View. Their son Julius grew up to become one of the town's earliest civic leaders. From 1886 to 1889, he served as the town's postmaster. Upon his father's death in 1899, Julius took over operation of the general store. During that same year, Julius married Fannie Ickleheimer. The town's affection for Julius is evident in the article recounting their wedding in the Mountain View *Register*:



"Our popular young merchant Julius Weilheimer and Miss Fannie Ickleheimer married in San Francisco last Sunday. Julius Weilheimer, 'our Julius', who has for so many years succeeded in running the gauntlet of bright-eyed maidens and disiguiing [sic] mamas, capitulated and joined the army of more or less happy benedicts, by leading to the altar Miss Fannie Ickleheimer of San Francisco."

The paper went on to note that the Weilheimers would, "...go at once to their new home, which has been furnished and fitted

...Continued on Page 5

The Weilheimer House (Continued from Page 4)

up in nice style." The new home mentioned in the article is the same house that stands today at 938 Villa Street, built c. 1900. The house is recognized as an "excellent example of a Queen Anne [Victorian] style cottage" in an architectural evaluation completed for the city by Carey & Co. Inc. Architecture in 2003. The house is one of the few buildings left in Downtown Mountain View that predates the 1906 earthquake and one of the few historic residences associated with the city's original merchant community still standing. Over the years, many of the homes of the Weilheimers' fellow merchants have been demolished to make way for downtown's parking lots and other developments. The most recent house lost to redevelopment is the Pearson House, formerly located next door at 902 Villa Street, built c. 1888 and demolished in 2013.

During his time living at 938 Villa Street, Julius helped lead the newly incorporated City of Mountain View. He was elected to the City Council in 1904 (then called the "Board of Trustees"). He served as the city's third mayor (then called "president") from 1906 to 1909. In 1905, his childhood friend Jacob Mockbee opened the Farmers & Merchants Bank at 201 Castro Street (now home to Red Rock Coffee). Julius served as the bank's first vice-president. In 1927, the bank became a branch of the Bank of Italy, now known as the Bank of America.

Sometime after 1909, Julius, Fannie, and their two daughters moved to San Francisco so that Julius could take over operation of his brother-in-law's businesses. Julius passed away from "an acute attack of indigestion" on December 31, 1922. When reporting his death the Mountain View *Register* wrote that "No man ever lived in this town who had more real sincere friends than Julius Weilheimer, He was honorable, clean and upright and had the heart of a child."

An article from the October 1997 edition of the *Western States Jewish History Journal* nicely summarizes the role of the Weilheimers in the region:

"They were an integral part of their community and heavily involved in the business, political and social aspects of the community. They were among the few Jewish families in Mountain View and they affiliated themselves with the large, vibrant Jewish community in San Francisco. Their descendants still live in the area and are still active in the Jewish community. The Weilheimer name will not be found on any street signs or city parks, yet they were the first of many Jews who would later build a large, dynamic community on the Peninsula."



In 1896, the Weilheimer general store was doubled in size, as shown above. It still stands today 124 Castro Street.

Today, the Weilheimer House stands as one of the most visible reminders of the Weilheimer family and the important role they played in the earliest decades of Mountain View's history. The pairing of a historic merchant family's home so close to the historic commercial building where they ran their business (124–126 Castro Street) is unique in Mountain View.



But the Weilheimers were not the only prominent Mountain View family to call 938 Villa Street home. Soon after the Weilheimers left Mountain View, the house was purchased by Arthur Free, who lived there with his family until 1914. During his time in Mountain View, Free built the foundation for a long political career. He served as Mountain View's first city attorney from 1904 to 1910 and as district attorney for Santa Clara County from 1907 to 1919. He was also appointed the town's postmaster by the federal government. Free was elected as a Republican to the 67th Congress of the United States and to the five succeeding Congresses (1921-1933), representing California's District 8, which at that time covered Monterey, San Benito, San Luis Obispo, San Mateo, Santa Barbara, Santa Clara, Santa Cruz, and Ventura counties.

Throughout the 20th century the house passed through a number of owners and occupants. For a brief period of time it was operated as a bed and breakfast named, appropriately, "The Weilheimer House." In the early 1980s, the property was purchased by George Aviet and Thomas J. McCombie, who opened their fine-dining French-inspired restaurant, Chez TJ, inside the historic house on November 26, 1982. Over the past 35 years, Chez TJ has earned a reputation as one of the Bay Area's best restaurants.

The next chapter in the Weilheimer House's history is clouded with great uncertainty. The current proposal put forth by the Minkoff Group—in partnership with Chez TJ and the Tied House—is to demolish all the structures on the site and replace them with a four-story office building. Although there is some talk of relocating the house, removing it from its context in Downtown Mountain View would greatly reduce its significance and value as a historic landmark.

For most of its history, Mountain View was a solidly working-class town full of enterprising merchants and hard-working immigrants from across the globe. Our historic landmarks are not grand mansions, domed civic buildings, or grand commercial edifices. They are the simple and stately old homes and commercial buildings that have survived decades of redevelopment and serve as proud reminders of our city's humble roots. The Weilheimer House at 938 Villa Street stands out among our city's collection of historic buildings, not just for its charming historic architecture but for the important role the people living inside it played in the town's early history. The fate of this house now lies with our City Council and the community it represents. The question before us is simple: Is Mountain View's history worth preserving?

Spring Meeting Recap

Japanese in Mountain View

By Marina Marinovich
MVHA Publicity Chair



Ellen Kamei helped organize the event's speakers and shared information on her family's history in Mtn.View.



Photos and mementos from Mtn.View's Japanese community were displayed during the event.



Panelists included L to R: Julie Satake Ryu, Ken Kamei and Wayne Adachi.



Mike Inouye, NBC Bay Area's weekday morning traffic anchor served as panel moderator.

The Mountain View Historical Association held its annual Spring Event & Membership Meeting 2017 at the Historic Adobe Building on May 7, 2017. The focus was on the history of Mountain View's Japanese American community. The event was timed to celebrate May as Asian Pacific American Heritage Month and to reflect on the 75th anniversary of Executive Order 9066, which authorized the forced removal of Japanese-American citizens and longtime residents from the West Coast. A panel of Mountain View's Japanese American community came together to share their stories and memories of being in the internment camps and of how being forced off their land affected their families forever.

South Bay native Mike Inouye, NBC Bay Area's weekday morning traffic anchor, served as moderator for the panel. Ellen Kamei, who helped organize the event's speakers, is a third-generation resident of Mountain View and currently serves on the city's Environmental Planning Commission. Ken Kamei, her father, was born in a Japanese internment camp during World War II. He was also part of the first graduating class of Graham Middle School.

Julie Satake Ryu presented two wonderful broadcast-quality short films that shared poignant Japanese American memories, stories, and photos all related to her own rich family history.

Wayne Adachi, who recently sold the last of his family's berry farm property in Mountain View, grew up on the Adachi Nursery and explained how foreign market trade and ever-increasing expenses eventually led to the demise of the flower industry here in the Bay Area.

Halle Sousa, a high school student and Mountain View native, presented a touching film she produced titled *Amache Remembered*. It is about the internment camp her grandfather was sent to during the war in Amache, Colorado. It can be found at the Japanese American Memorial Society web site.

Stories were shared about their respective families' histories. There was felt to be a strong mutual respect and camaraderie between the panel members based on their shared history of growing up in farming families in the Mtn. View area. Their grandfathers and fathers were founding supporters of the Buddhist Temple that served as a backbone for their community. It helped to strengthen and unify them as they faced the challenges of attending school as members of a minority group.

The MVHA would like to thank everyone who participated in the panel and attended the event. We hope to continue to offer programs such as this that give the many diverse communities that have called Mountain View home a chance to reflect on their history and share their stories.

954 Villa Street History

By Candace Bowers & Nick Perry
MVHA President & Vice President

Like the historic Weilheimer House next door, the building housing the Tied House Brewery at 954 Villa Street faces demolition. The MVHA has combed through our records to provide the following timeline of the building's history in anticipation of upcoming discussions on its future.

**MVRL denotes Mountain View Register-Leader newspaper*

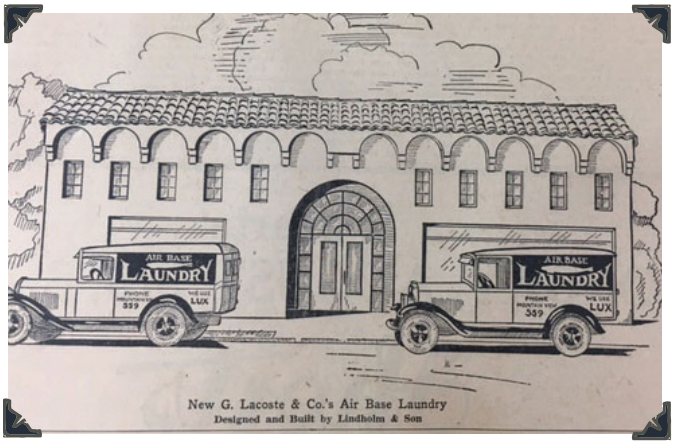
1931 July 31 (MVRL)
Two-page spread on the opening of the Air Base Laundry; George Lacoste, owner; designed and built by Carl Lindholm & Sons, general contractors and builders.

1935 Dec. 27 (MVRL): Air Base Laundry changes name to Band Box Laundry and Dry Cleaning Company. Walter Doust, proprietor

1938 Dec. 8 (MVRL): Band Box bought by Dan Harris; name changed to Fremont Laundry (name was picked in a contest; winner won $10)

1962 Jan. 24 (MV *Herald*): Fremont Laundry opens a new building at 990 Villa.

1968 City Directory: Listed as the location of Meyer Electric



A rendering of the Air Base Laundry appeared on the front page of the 1931 Mountain View *Register-Leader*

1978 City Directory: Listed as the location of the Light Station, lighting and décor

1988 *Peninsula Times Tribune* article about the opening of the Tied House; mentions the City owns the building and land, and Tied House will lease the property with the option to buy.

2003 Historic Resource Survey completed by Carey & Company finds the building is "historically significant for its direct association with the 20th century development of Mountain View's downtown and for its architectural distinction as an excellent example of a Spanish Eclectic style commercial building."

MEMBERSHIP FORM + BBQ TICKETS

The MVHA welcomes new members! By becoming a member, you are making a special investment in our mission to preserve and share Mtn. View history with the community, conserve priceless archival materials at the History Center, and hold memorable public events throughout the year. Please support the MVHA, and join us today!

- ☐ BBQ Ticket Order Only
- ☐ New Membership
- ☐ Membership Renewal
- ☐ Single Membership: *$15/year*
- ☐ Family Membership: *$25/year*
- ☐ Life Membership *$200*
- ☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*

Name: _____

Street Address: _____

City: _____

State: _____ Zip Code: _____

Telephone: _____

E-mail: _____

Please make checks payable to:
Mtn. View Historical Association

Mail this form to:
Mountain View Historical Association
c/o Lisa Garcia
P.O. Box 252
Mtn. View, CA 94042

BBQ TICKETS

To order your tickets for our Aug. 20 BBQ, fill out the form below and mail it and a check by Friday, August 11 to our P.O. Box (address above). Each ticket gets you one Parisian burger with a side of tots (aka "super fries"), prepared by the Gold Rush Eatery. You can also purchase tickets online at: **http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com/**

____ # MVHA Member BBQ Ticket ($10) *Not a member? Join today and save $5 on your BBQ ticket!*

____ # Guest/Non-Member BBQ Ticket ($15)

____ # Child BBQ Ticket ($5)

SUMMER/FALL

August 20
Sunday, 12:00 to 2:00 p.m.
MVHA Summer BBQ
Adobe Building - 157 Moffett Blvd.
See Page 7 for Details!

Sept. 6
Wednesday, 6:30 to 8:00 p.m.
MVHA Summer Board Meeting
M.V. Library History Center, 585 Franklin St.
All interested members welcome to attend!

October 7
Saturday, Time TBD
Mtn. View High Eagles All-Class Picnic
Cuesta Park BBQ Area–615 Cuesta Dr.
Details are tentative, check our Facebook page for the latest info.

November 5
Sunday, 1:00 to 2:30 p.m.
MVHA Fall Event/Meeting
Adobe Building - 157 Moffett Blvd.
Our Dia de los Muertos celebration returns! More info in our fall newsletter.



SUMMER BBQ & MVHA MEMBERSHIP MEETING

Sunday, August 20, 2017
12:00 to 2:00 p.m.
Adobe Building - 157 Moffett Blvd.

See President's Message on page 2 for more info on BBQ and page 7 for ticket order form, or visit: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com/

EST. 1954
MOUNTAIN REVIEW
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